Postage Stamp Lesson

Target Grade Range: 3rd-5th

Overview:

This lesson teaches that a postage stamp is more than just a sticker on an envelope; it is a tiny piece of history. Students will meet W. W. Law (1923-2002), a long-time mail carrier in Savannah, Georgia, who also led the NAACP for 26 years. They will see how the correspondence he wrote, received, and delivered helps us understand his community's work for fairness and equal rights. By looking closely at stamps, envelopes, letters, and postcards from the archives, students will practice thinking like historians and archivists. Then they will design a stamp to honor a person, place, or idea that matters to them.

What is a Primary Source:

A primary source is something created by someone who lived through an event or time period, or created at the time it happened. It gives us a first-hand look at the past. Letters, diaries, photographs, newspapers, maps, recordings, and objects such as tools, clothing, and stamps are all primary sources.

A secondary source is created later by someone who wasn't there, such as a textbook, an encyclopedia, or a documentary. Secondary sources help explain the past, but primary sources let us look at the past for ourselves.

A simple way to remember the difference: a photograph taken at your birthday party is a primary source. The story a friend tells you about your party a week later is a secondary source.

Primary sources are cared for in archives. An archive is a place where people called archivists collect, protect, and organize important records so that people today, and people in the future, can study them.

Video: Social Studies with The Southern Tech. "What are Primary and Secondary Sources? | How to Teach Social Studies Skills

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Tbth_A_Urd8

Stamps as primary sources:

A postage stamp is a primary source because it was made at a certain time, for a certain purpose, and it carries clues about that time. When students study a stamp, they can learn:

- **When it was made.** Many stamps show a year. A postmark, the mark the post office puts on an envelope, shows the date and place where the letter was mailed.
- **What mailing a letter cost.** The number on a stamp (its denomination) shows the price of postage when the stamp was used.
- **Who or what a country chose to honor.** The person, place, or event on a stamp was picked on purpose.
- **How people made art at that time.** The colors, lettering, and style of a stamp show what was popular when it was designed.
- **What was important to people then.** Stamps often celebrate achievements, anniversaries, and events.

A stamp also shows a point of view. Someone decided whose picture would be on it and what story it would tell. Historians ask: Who chose this? Who is honored? Whose story is not on a stamp yet? These questions help students see that history is made of many voices.

Stamps and postmarks on W. W. Law's letters and postcards can tell us when and where his letters traveled. LINK to an example envelope from the Law collection showing a stamp and postmark

About W. W. Law, the Letter Carrier:

Westley Wallace "W. W." Law was born in Savannah, Georgia, on January 1, 1923. He worked as a letter carrier for the U.S. Postal Service for more than forty years, walking his routes and delivering mail to his neighbors. At the same time, he was one of Savannah's most important Civil Rights leaders. He joined the NAACP Youth Council in high school, and from 1950 to 1976 he was president of the Savannah branch of the NAACP. He died on July 29, 2002.

Things students may find interesting:

- **Letters were part of his work and his life**. He delivered letters every day, and as a community leader, he also wrote and received many letters, including letters with national Civil Rights leaders. The archives care for this correspondence, which lets us see who Law worked with and hear his voice. LINK to one or two example letters
- **He worked for fairness.** During Law's lifetime, unfair laws and customs in the South kept Black and white people apart, a practice called segregation. Law and others in Savannah worked to change this through peaceful, organized action: community meetings, lawsuits, and a long boycott of downtown businesses. Many people credit Law with helping keep Savannah's Civil Rights movement peaceful.

- **He faced a hard time, and people stood up for him.** In 1961, Law lost his postal job because of his Civil Rights work. National NAACP leaders and President John F. Kennedy spoke up for him, and he got his job back.
- **He loved history.** He was a local historian who worked to protect Savannah's African American history. He helped create museums and programs, including the Ralph Mark Gilbert Civil Rights Museum. Like an archivist, he believed in saving the past for the future.
- **He worked with young people.** He was scoutmaster of Troop 49 at First Bryan Baptist Church, where he also taught Sunday school.
- **Read-aloud idea:** Delivering Justice: W. W. Law and the Fight for Civil Rights by Jim Haskins is an illustrated biography written for young readers.

  Purchase here: https://www.amazon.com/dp/0763625922?lv=shuf&channelId=500&plpRedirect=mhFallback

  YouTube reading: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=FfFQU2bfmVg

Teacher tip: Law's story includes segregation and unfair treatment. Share it honestly in a way that fits your students' ages. Focus on the courage, teamwork, and peaceful action of Law and his community, and give students time to share how they feel. It is fine to say, "That was unfair," and to talk about how people worked to change it.

Objectives:

- Understand the purpose and history of postage stamps
- Understand the value of stamps as historical records
- Explain the difference between a primary source and a secondary source, and give examples of each
- Identify the key elements that make an effective postage stamp design
- Create a unique postage stamp that reflects a chosen theme or idea
- Demonstrate a comprehension of composition, color, and symbolism in their designs
- Describe how W. W. Law's work as a letter carrier and community leader connects to letters, communication, and civil rights in Savannah

Time Required:

Note: Video times are not included in the total.

About 70 to 90 minutes in total. This lesson works well as two class sessions of about 45 minutes each, taught on the same day or on separate days.

- **Session 1:** Introduction, Meet the Mail Carrier, Primary Source Detective, and Brainstorming (about 40–50 minutes)
- **Session 2:** Sketching and Planning, Final Design, and Closing (about 35–40 minutes, plus set-up and clean-up)

Topic(s): Social Studies, Art, local history

Standards:

Social Studies (Georgia Standards of Excellence)

- **SS5H6 (Grade 5):** Describe the importance of key people, events, and developments between 1950 and 1975. (a) Describe the effects of Jim Crow laws and practices. (b) Explain key events and people of the Civil Rights Movement.
- **SS4H6.d (Grade 4):** Describe the effects of Jim Crow laws and practices.
- **SS4CG2 (Grade 4):** Explain the importance of the freedoms guaranteed by the First Amendment, such as gathering peacefully and asking the government to fix problems.
- **SS3CG2.b (Grade 3):** Explain why it is important for citizens in a democracy to take part in public life, including staying informed, volunteering, and communicating with public officials.
- **SS5CG1.a (Grade 5):** Explain the responsibilities of a citizen.
- **Social Studies Information Processing Skills (Grades 3–5):** identify and use primary and secondary sources; analyze artifacts; compare similarities and differences; draw conclusions and make generalizations.

Visual Art (Georgia Standards of Excellence)

- **VA3.CR.2 (Grade 3):** Create works of art based on selected themes
- **VA3.PR.1 (Grade 3):** Plan and participate in appropriate exhibition(s) of works of art to develop identity of self as artist.
- **VA4.CR.1 (Grade 4):** Engage in the creative process to generate and visualize ideas by using subject matter and symbols to communicate meaning.
- **VA4.PR.1 (Grade 4):** Plan and participate in appropriate exhibition(s) of works of art to develop identity of self as artist.
- **VA5.CR.1 (Grade 5):** Engage in the creative process to generate and visualize ideas by using subject matter to communicate meaning.
- **VA5.PR.1 (Grade 5):** Plan and participate in appropriate exhibition(s) of works of art to develop identity of self as artist.

Materials:

- Various examples of postage stamps (physical or digital)
- Pencils and erasers
- Colored pencils, markers, or watercolors
- Ruler
- Stamp template
- Copies of letters, envelopes, postcards, and photographs from the W. W. Law collection. Copies are best for classroom handling so the originals stay safe.
- Primary Source Detective worksheet (Student Handout 1, at the end of this document)
- Stamp Design Checklist (Student Handout 2, at the end of this document)
- Magnifying glasses (optional, but students love them)
- Sticky notes for the gallery walk

Key Vocabulary:

- **Archive:** a place that keeps important records safe so people can study them
- **Archivist:** a person who collects, protects, and organizes records in an archive
- **Primary source:** something made at the time of an event or by someone who was there
- **Secondary source:** something made later by someone who was not there
- **Correspondence:** letters written back and forth between people
- **Postmark:** a mark from the post office that shows the date and place a letter was mailed
- **Denomination:** the amount of money a stamp is worth
- **Commemorate:** to honor or remember a person or event
- **Symbol:** a picture or object that stands for an idea
- **Civil rights:** the rights every person should have, such as being treated fairly and equally
- **Segregation:** the unfair practice of keeping people of different races apart
- **Boycott:** choosing not to buy from a business in order to protest unfair treatment
- **NAACP:** the National Association for the Advancement of Colored People, a group founded in 1909 to work for equal rights

[Suggested Program]

Introduction (10-15 minutes):

Hook (2–3 minutes)

- Hold up an old envelope with a stamp and a postmark without opening it. LINK to an example envelope from the archives. **Ask:** What can we learn just from the outside? Who sent it? When? Where? How much did it cost to mail?
- Tell students that today they will be history detectives.

Discuss the History of Postage Stamps

History of the postage stamp video: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=_qQ-lHbzVng

- Briefly discuss the history of postage stamps, including when and why they were created
- Show examples of famous or unique postage stamps from around the world. What makes them different? What stands out to you?
- Explain the significance of postage stamps beyond their use in mailing, such as how they represent cultures, countries, and certain events.
- Fun fact: before stamps, the person receiving a letter often paid for it. The first sticky postage stamp, the Penny Black, came out in Great Britain in 1840. The first U.S. stamps came out in 1847 and showed Benjamin Franklin and George Washington.

Analyze Stamp Design Elements

- Break down the components of a postage stamp: size, imagery, text, borders, and denomination
- Discuss how these elements work together to convey a message or theme
- Emphasize the use of a small design due to the size of the stamp

Meet the Mail Carrier: W. W. Law (10–15 minutes):

Introduce a Letter Carrier Who Helped Change Savannah

- **Ask:** Who brings the mail to your home? What do you think a letter carrier's day is like?
- **Share a short version of Law's story.** You may read parts of *Delivering Justice* aloud, or use this student-friendly summary: "W. W. Law delivered mail in Savannah, Georgia, for more than forty years. He walked the streets and knew his neighbors. He also believed everyone should be treated fairly. Together with many others, he worked peacefully to end unfair rules that kept Black and white people apart. He held meetings, wrote letters, and helped people work together to make change. He also loved history and worked to save Savannah's stories for the future."
- **Show a photograph of W. W. Law.**

- **Ask:** Why might a letter carrier know a lot about what a neighborhood needs? How can letters help people work together?

Primary Source Detective (10 minutes):

Look Closely at Letters, Postcards, and Stamps

- Explain primary and secondary sources using the birthday party example. Remind students that stamps are primary sources too.
- Place students in small groups. Give each group one item from the archives: a postcard or an envelope with a stamp and a postmark.
- Groups complete the Primary Source Detective worksheet: Look (what do you see?), Think (who made it, when, and why?), and Wonder (what questions do you still have?).
- Each group shares one discovery with the class. Ask: What clues does the stamp give us?
- Remind students that archivists handle old items very carefully: clean, dry hands and flat on the table.

Activity: Designing a Postage Stamp (30-40 minutes)

Brainstorming (10 minutes):

- Have students choose a theme for their stamp (a national park, a historical figure, a cultural event, an abstract concept like “peace”). You can break up into smaller groups here, if desired
- Encourage students to think about what symbols, colors, or images would best represent their chosen theme
- For a W. W. Law connection, invite students to design a stamp for someone who “delivers” something important to their community, such as a helper, leader, or neighbor. Students may also design a stamp that honors W. W. Law himself.

Sketching and Planning (10 minutes):

- Students can use scrap pieces of (4x6) paper to plan out their postage stamp designs, considering the layout, color schemes, and the inclusion of necessary elements such as the country name and denomination
- Remind students to keep their designs simple but impactful
- Encourage students to plan each part of the stamp: image, words, border, and denomination. Ask them to think about what each color or symbol means.

Final Design (15-20 minutes):

- Students will select their best sketch and create a detailed version using colored pencils, markers, or watercolors. Template provided.
- Ask students to write a one- or two-sentence artist statement on the back or on a small card: Who or what is on your stamp? Why did you choose it? Students may also add a postmark with a date and place.

Closing (10 minutes):

- Once completed, students can display their stamps around the classroom.
- Conduct a gallery walk where students can appreciate each design and discuss its meaning
- During the gallery walk, students leave sticky notes that begin "I notice…" or "I wonder…".
- Return to the envelope from the hook. Ask: What new clues can you find now that you have studied stamps?
- **Exit question:** What is one thing a stamp can tell us about the past?

Cross-Curricular Connection:

- Connect with other subjects by having students research an important figure or event for their stamp design. Example: Katherine Johnson for Science or Math; Frederick McKinley for Inventors.
- **English Language Arts:** Have students write a thank-you letter to a community helper, then design the stamp for the envelope.
- **Math:** Compare the cost of mailing a letter today with the cost long ago. Use denominations to practice addition and comparing numbers.
- **Geography:** Find Savannah on a map. Trace the path a letter might take from Savannah to another city or state.

Critical Thinking Questions

- Why do you think designers choose specific images, colors, or symbols for postage stamps?
- In what ways can a postage stamp be a miniature work of art?
- How might the size of a postage stamp influence its design?
- Why is it important for a postage stamp to convey its message clearly and effectively?
- How do you think the theme of a postage stamp is chosen?
- How can a postage stamp reflect current events or social issues?

- How do you think cultural differences influence the design of postage stamps in different countries?
- In what ways might a design be different today than 100 years ago?

Additional Questions About Primary Sources and W. W. Law:

- What is one thing a letter can tell us that a textbook cannot?
- Why do you think archives keep old letters and envelopes?
- Why might a letter carrier be a good person to know what a neighborhood needs?
- How can writing letters help people work together to make change?
- How can one person's job, like delivering mail, connect to something bigger?
- If W. W. Law were on a stamp, what images, colors, and words would you choose? Why?
- Whose stories do you not see on stamps yet? Who would you add?

Extension Activities:

- **Class letter:** Students write to the City Manager or the Mayor.
- **Life timeline:** Students make a timeline of W. W. Law's life using at least five dates.
- **Ask an archivist:** Invite an archivist to visit, or plan an archives visit so students can ask questions.
- **Class stamp sheet:** Combine student designs into one large sheet of stamps to display in the classroom or school library.
- **Stamps through time:** Students sort stamps by decade and talk about how the designs change.
- **Ask a mail carrier.** Invite a mail carrier to visit so students can ask questions.
- **Ask an artist:** Invite a local artist to visit so students can ask questions.

Supporting All Learners:

- **Grade 3:** Offer sentence starters ("I see…", "I think…", "I wonder…") and a word bank. Use fewer items in the detective activity.
- **Grade 5:** Ask students to compare two sources, such as a stamp and a letter, or to write a longer artist statement that explains their choices.
- **Extra drawing support:** Allow collage or tracing, offer a partly drawn template, or let students pair up.
- **English learners:** Pair students with a partner, and add pictures to the vocabulary list.

Student Handout 1: Primary Source Detective

Name: _____ Date: _____

Our item is: ☐ envelope with a stamp ☐ postcard

LOOK: What do you see? List three things.

THINK: Who made it? When was it made? Why do you think it was made?

WONDER: What questions do you still have?

Is this a primary source? How do you know?

Student Handout 2: Stamp Design Checklist

Name: _____ Date: _____

Before you finish, check your stamp:

☐ My stamp has a clear picture or image.

☐ My stamp has words, such as a name or a place.

☐ My stamp has a denomination (how much it is worth).

☐ I used colors and symbols on purpose.

☐ My design is simple enough to be seen clearly, even though it is small.

☐ I wrote an artist statement.

Artist statement: Who or what is on my stamp? Why did I choose it?